Session 12

2025-05-25

1 - Under the second sun

~22:30, 1 Uktar 1489 DR

1. It is late in the autumn evening when the party rides up to the walls of Elturel. Full night should be on them, but the Light of Elturel hangs over the city like a small sun of its own — Nyx notes it sits directly above them, catching them from overhead the way the true sun would at noon, and the party remarks that it must be miserable to actually live under a light that never dims.
2. Inside the walls Elturel shows itself as civilised in a way the party has not seen for weeks — wide, well-guarded, clean streets kept lit by the constant sun overhead. The river Chionthar runs straight through the city, busy in both directions — barges downstream with the current, mule-teams towing barges back upstream along tow-paths on either bank.
3. Amidamaru and Nuberroca ride in still fresh, Nyx and Eguzkilore a shade footsore. They make straight for the tavern the Elturel gate-guard had named — **A Pair of Black Antlers** — with no complication reaching it.

2 - The paladin of Torm

1. At the back of the common room the party spots **Leosin** at once — laughing and talking with a big, plate-armoured human whose breastplate carries the golden hand of **Torm**, and one gauntlet of his armour painted blue as a personal token of his faith. Around them a knot of other armoured folk are arm-wrestling, throwing an odd gauntlet-wrestling match, generally cutting loose.
2. Nyx orders a cup of wine, Nuberroca a full gallon of beer, Eguzkilore his own jar, Amidamaru waves off drink for now. The tavern's two-gold rate covers a room, dinner and next morning's breakfast — a shared board of bread, cheese and small plates is a silver a head on the side, and Nyx pays for it.
3. Nyx walks up to Leosin's table with the ease of a lifelong friend and drops into a seat. **Ontharr Frume** — the plate-armoured man — sizes her up but lets her stay; then Leosin calls them *"the heroes of Greenest,"* granting that thanks to them he made it out of the cultists' hands alive, though he adds a wry qualifier that they hadn't done all that much for the escape itself.
4. Their briefers ask whether they gathered any intelligence at the cultists' lair. Nyx spreads Mondath's papers on the table — the map of the Greenfields region, the notes ordering everything the raiders steal to be carried north to **Naerytar**, **Rezmir's** allowance of some of the pearls, and a sheaf of dragon-poems the two men wave off as uninteresting.
5. Ontharr and Leosin trace the route on the map with the party — from Greenfields the cult marches west, then north up the Trade Way through Baldur's Gate and on toward a place they call *Naerytar*, which no one recognises. Between them the party sizes the cult's lead at about six days; Ontharr reckons the cultists on foot are about a week from Baldur's Gate at that pace.
6. Ontharr adds a grim wrinkle — the order's scouts have been watching the whole Sword Coast and see no sign of them, no army-movement, nothing hostile, *"as if they had vanished."* The party suggests the cult may be moving as many small parties rather than one column; Ontharr agrees that fits the silence.
7. Ontharr sees the party is running on nothing, notes Sinsong and Mialee already nodding into the table, and offers to save the substance of it for the morning — first hour after sun-up, in the tavern's private room. Meanwhile, if any of them want a game, his companions will oblige.

3 – Ontharr's duel

1. Nuberroca walks up to Ontharr, looks him over, and tells him he looks strong. Ontharr reads it right — is this a challenge? Nuberroca, with a small shrug, allows that if Ontharr will have it he came only to say so, but *"nos podemos pegar unas hostias si quieres"*. Ontharr's people take him at his word and the whole common room opens a ring around them.
2. Nyx clambers onto a table to open the pool — two gold on the goliath. One of the civilians edges forward to take her bet against his boss; Nuberroca stops the pool with a soldier's line — this isn't right, this is just a warmup between warriors.
3. Ontharr strips down slowly — his plates take a helper to unlace — then a padded gambeson comes off to reveal a builder's mass of muscle. Without armour or weapons he sets himself and waves Nuberroca in. With Nuberroca's kill-joy line still in the air, Nyx starts to pocket the money — until Leosin arrives at her elbow and lays five gold on Ontharr; Nyx takes the bet, five gold on Nuberroca. Nuberroca starts his pec-flexing routine for the crowd.
4. Reading the pec-flexing as readiness, Ontharr opens first — and catches only air, as Nuberroca ducks low to remove his pants. Ontharr calls him off at once: pants stay on, as he has kept his own.
5. ***[EPIC]*** Nuberroca comes back all-in, no guard, and his first punch lands so hard Ontharr coughs up a smear of blood — the room reads it: the paladin is stronger but slow, and the goliath has more than a puncher's chance. Two rounds later Nuberroca sees Ontharr fighting confident and open, hits him again with the same full commitment; the paladin's answering swing goes past him miserably, badly out of practice fighting without steel around him. The room erupts and starts clapping the goliath; Leosin hands Nyx her five gold, well-earned.
6. Ontharr accepts the loss cleanly. He gathers Nuberroca into a wide grin and allows that if all the goliath's companions are half as good, tearing down the cult of the dragon will be a walk in the park, then starts strapping his plates back on with a wry note that he is out of practice fighting bare. Nuberroca puts out a hand, calls him a knight of honour, and slides the barrel of beer over for him to share; Nyx offers him her wine too.

4 – Rooms and rest

1. Before turning in, Amidamaru asks the tavern-keeper about couriers to **Westgate** and hands over a sealed letter. Two gold buys it first-caravan carriage east in the morning — around forty to fifty days on the road.
2. The party takes six individual rooms at two gold apiece — no need to share this time. Amidamaru asks for breakfast brought to his door for five copper; Nyx laughs and undercuts the tavern-keeper by a piece, offering to bring it up herself for four. Amidamaru pays the tavern-keeper anyway.
3. Amidamaru announces his plan for the night's off-hours before heading up — some tinkering with his equipment — refining the small enchanted focuses he uses to shape spells. Nyx, deadpan, observes that the whole thing sounds suspiciously like a euphemism.

5 – Late to the meeting

~08:00, 2 Uktar 1489 DR

1. Morning arrives with a knock — eight in the morning. Amidamaru asks for the tray to be left at the door, opens a crack, hooks it in, and shuts himself back up. The night's rest bleeds the worst of the exhaustion off the party.
2. Amidamaru stays upstairs. Nuberroca, Nyx, and Eguzkilore drag themselves down to the common room — and find Ontharr openly angry. They are nearly two hours late; the sun came up at half past six and they were supposed to meet in the private room then. Nuberroca apologises with a grin: they came in dead-tired, and the beating Ontharr gave him didn't help him rise. Ontharr breaks into a smile.
3. Eguzkilore heads back up to knock on Amidamaru's door — for the turtle... well, for the elf — he corrects himself mid-word, mindful the disguise is on. Amidamaru pulls himself together in ten minutes and comes down. Mialee and Sinsong are left to sleep.
4. The private room is small — a table, four chairs, no windows, some of the order's storage stacked against the walls, and one of the Gauntlet on guard at the door. Nyx settles on the floor rather than press one of the standing party to the wall.

6 - Several dragons

1. Ontharr opens flat: the situation is complicated — the cult of the dragon is organising something large and they don't yet know what. What the party's own intelligence has confirmed is that they are hoarding treasure and moving it. The order has agents trying to trace the destination and no answer yet.
2. From the papers the party brought they now know the caravan is bound for Baldur's Gate along the trade route — that is the point to intercept and infiltrate, and the order is counting on the party to be the ones who do it.
3. Ontharr names the wider alliance for them: he speaks for the **Order of the Gauntlet**, Leosin for the **Harpers**; also with them are the **Lords' Alliance** and the **Emerald Enclave**, all working to break the cult.
4. Ontharr closes the pitch on why the party is needed — the future of the civilised world hangs on understanding what *the dragon* is doing. Amidamaru raises a hand tentatively — Ontharr said *the* dragon, singular, but there is more than one. Yes, Ontharr answers — many.
5. Amidamaru presses on with his voice starting to tremble — *how many, and what does the order know of them?*. Ontharr answers first with the name: the cult calls itself for THE dragon — **Tiamat**, goddess of chromatic dragons. *And that is bad*, Amidamaru offers back; yes, quite bad, Ontharr answers. Cells of the cult have historically turned dragons into dracoliches, one at a time — never before now a coordinated operation at this scale.
6. Amidamaru asks the count. At least five confirmed, Ontharr answers: the blue the party saw at Greenest; a red that has worked with it in the north, plus either that same red also striking other cities, or two more reds beyond it; and a white.
7. Nuberroca asks whether such creatures can be beaten. Individually, Ontharr allows, even without joining forces it should not be too hard; the problem is not the single dragon — it is *why they are gathering together at all*. That has no precedent Ontharr knows.
8. Asked for their help, the party assents — Nuberroca first, plainly. Eguzkilore nods behind him. Amidamaru rounds it out: *within our means, and trying to fight as little as possible, infiltration sounds a good plan*.
9. Nuberroca sets the table with a second thread of his own — far to the north his tribe is holding back a slow tide of undead they cannot trace, and his elders sent him south for allies. Ontharr cannot spare force now, but he vows the order will help once the cult is put down. Leosin, more concretely, offers to put a few Harpers agents on the trail and to try to trace the source. Ontharr adds his own guess — if Nuberroca's home is near the border with **Thay**, the **Red Wizards** are stirring again, and undead would fit their pattern.

7 - Factions and gear

1. Amidamaru brings the meeting back to logistics — the party needs healing potions and coin, and asks Leosin for any work in town in the meantime. Leosin waves it off: time is not on their side. The order will get them a boat downriver — four or five days with the current, no fee. They keep the horses to Baldur's Gate, then hand them to the Harpers waiting there — mounts can't cross the city. The order can spare twenty gold and a healing potion each — no more.
2. Leosin turns the offer over — would either of them care to join? Nyx asks for more first. The Harpers work to end tyranny and keep no single group too powerful; they were nearly wiped out once for being too open, and now work in secret, cell-by-cell, gathering intelligence for the general good.
3. Ontharr makes a buzz-kill wave behind Leosin's back — cowards, he calls them; the Gauntlet does the same work but marches out openly and puts the enemy down. Sign with the Gauntlet and they'll have equipment, backing, and quarters.
4. Nuberroca answers Ontharr on the spot. Nyx, more careful, asks whether joining is for life; there's a probationary period as a rule, though given the circumstances they'd waive it. Leosin, plainly, has been eyeing Nyx; Ontharr, Nuberroca.
5. Ontharr takes Nuberroca first. The goliath boasts of noble blood — a descendant of the titans — and tosses a gold piece to the table for effect: they may prize the metal, but where he comes from this is worth nothing. Ontharr asks his rank and steers toward the order's principles: what he wants of Nuberroca back north is that he be a bulwark of them — *"el orden, la ley y el bien, defender a los inocentes y perseguir a los culpables"*. Nuberroca says his people already do that. Then it is done — he signs to the Gauntlet.
6. Nyx works Leosin quietly: she has a family to return to eventually. No problem — the Harpers work in independent cells, called in only when needed. She signs. Leosin gives her a Harpers pendant — a leather cord with a harp pierced by a sword, matching his own.
7. Ontharr equips Nuberroca at once — scale mail with the sigil of Torm on the breast (a step up from bare, at the cost of moving less quietly), a shield with the order's mark, and a halberd. No helmet on offer.
8. Amidamaru asks after some order that traffics in gems and diamonds — pearls and diamonds specifically, to be of more use to the party. The nearest fit is the Lords' Alliance, but the alliance takes nobles or a city's representative; the party's claim as *saviours of Greenest* falls short because Greenest is a village, not a city. Amidamaru shrugs it off.

8 - The last errands

1. The party sits to the porridge left out for them from the morning — cold enough by now to have set like a cast. The tavern-keeper offers to warm it; Nuberroca waves him off — cold is fine, let's eat — and a jug of beer helps it down.
2. Before they leave, Amidamaru circles back to the tavern-keeper to ask after his first letter — sent that morning with the eastbound caravan, he's told. He hands over a second sealed letter for the same destination; the tavern-keeper warns this one will take longer to get through.
3. When asked about a jeweller, the tavern-keeper points them toward the merchants' quarter down by the river — the shop is close. Amidamaru heads out; Nyx asks the tavern-keeper's leave to bring her breakfast plate along, promising to return it, then follows; Nuberroca shovels his own porridge down whole and comes along; Eguzkilore falls in.

9 - Merchants' quarter

~09:30, 2 Uktar 1489 DR

1. The party walks along the Chionthar to the merchants' quarter — a busy river-port with warehouses, dockhands, and heavy guards. The first thing to catch the eye is the crowd of ragged street-children working the crowd for pockets.
2. Nuberroca pockets his gold and slings the pouch on a cord around his neck like a pendant. Amidamaru ensures that anything worth stealing on him is inside his shell. Nyx just rests a hand on her pouch.
3. Within minutes Amidamaru is brushed by a small child — the child breaks off and runs, and Nyx spots the attempt. Amidamaru pats himself down; nothing missing. Nyx guesses the shell rebuffed the child — and adds that the child now knows there is something strange about him.
4. Nuberroca warns the party he'll slap away anything that gets within reach.
5. Soon after, the same child steps back out of a side-alley and points Amidamaru out to five men following him — armed, though the weapons are poorly hidden under long coats. As the men close, the street-crowd around them peels back without needing to be told.
6. Nuberroca does not want to be surrounded in a crowd; he tells the party to get into the shop — *"vámonos, o me pongo violento"*. Amidamaru plays it flat and walks on to the jeweller's door.

10 - The gnome's shop

1. Inside the shop Amidamaru shifts his shape again — the elf gives way to a semi-orc. The jeweller — a gnome — goes pale, unsettled by the magic in his own shop and beginning to press something under the counter with one hand.
2. Amidamaru tells the jeweller that bandits outside mean to rob them all, then drops fifty gold on the counter and asks for a diamond, urgently. Nuberroca arrives a beat later, half-inside and half-planted in the doorframe as a wall so the bandits cannot follow him in, and repeats the word — urgently!. The jeweller doesn't move on it, and Amidamaru quietly pockets the fifty gold again.
3. The jeweller's answer is flat — he doesn't like his clients changing appearance, it raises suspicions, and suspicions aren't good for business. Nyx presses him — they are being followed, they wanted the change so as to lose them; he answers that the party's trouble is theirs to keep out of his shop. Nuberroca sharpens the pressure — he'll have that trouble either way if he refuses to help. Nyx asks after the city guard; on the way, the jeweller replies. He then reads the whole exchange as a threat.
4. The jeweller pulls a lever. In the blink of an eye, iron plates come down from the ceiling and slam the shop shut — the counter is cut off, the displays are cut off, only the outer door still stands. Then mechanical sounds start above their heads — something is moving in the ceiling; Nuberroca smells a trap. Amidamaru glances up: from each corner, tubes are lowering, widening at their ends, and after a beat's swing they pivot as if to aim.
5. Amidamaru shouts to run and the party bolts back out through the door, closing it behind them as something *whooshes* against it from the inside and the door starts running warm.

11 - The street fight

1. The bandits are waiting where the party left them, and the leader looks them over, asking where the elf is. Amidamaru answers first: he stayed inside, the fire got him. Nyx echoes the story. The leader is not buying — the cover falls flat.
2. The leader closes on the party and reads them one by one — he's seen Nuberroca before, he's seen the halfling before too, and Nyx eases back to keep the distance; but the semi-orc who wasn't with them coming in is the one he wants to talk to, alone.
3. Amidamaru takes the singling-out as his cue — he calmly sneaks out of the leader's field; the moment he's clear he slips a spell of *invisibility* onto himself.
4. Rage takes Nuberroca and he closes the gap in a single stride, lunging for the grapple, demanding *"¿a quién coño te estás acercando tú?"*. The leader slips clean out of it and warns him back — *"las manitas quietas"* — it's not in the party's interest to get involved with them.
5. ***[EPIC]*** Nuberroca doesn't stand down — he drives the halberd in once, a punishing cut, and the killer's touch in him sinks it deeper still. Nuberroca stays swinging in the same motion — the polearm's butt-end comes over onto the adjacent bandit, cracking his head and leaving him dead on the stones.
6. The two bandits furthest back break — they turn on their heels and vanish into the crowd; the wounded leader flees alongside them. The remaining two draw and charge Nuberroca.
7. Nuberroca meets the nearest with a swing as he comes into reach; the bandit's answering strike catches him too, but a moment later a blue glow rises over the cut and the flesh knits back closed.
8. Nyx strikes with the pommel of her weapon and drops the bandit facing her unconscious. Eguzkilore swings his own scimitar and fumbles it. Amidamaru, still invisible, uses the moment to slip further away, walking with as much stealth as he can manage.
9. The last bandit still on his feet sees his fellow put down alive rather than killed, throws his weapons to the ground, and flattens himself onto the stones.
10. Nuberroca wants the wounded leader — badly hurt and bleeding hard from the halberd cut — and tears off down the crowded street to run him down, banking on the visible blood-trail. The crowd swallows the man before Nuberroca can pick him up; he comes back empty-handed.
11. Nyx and Nuberroca question the bandit on his knees: what did he want with the elf? He doesn't know — Arthax told them to interrogate the elf and they came. Nuberroca grapples him and ropes his arms to march him off with them.

12 - The guards arrive

1. Barely ten seconds pass between the fight ending and the whistles — the crowd has already circled up around the dead man in the street, and the party has been seen.
2. Eguzkilore refuses to run this time; he wants to explain. He sheathes his weapons and waits. Nyx follows him: sword back into scabbard, hands up in plain sight.
3. The guards arrive at pace. They fix on Nuberroca first — he is the tallest man there, the crowd is pointing him out, and the armour with the sigil of Torm is easily recognisable. They ask what happened.
4. Nyx and Eguzkilore speak first — the party was attacked, they defended themselves; but the guards answer that the crowd is telling them the party attacked without provocation. Nuberroca ropes the tied bandit closer and prompts him to repeat what he'd told them on their walk over — that Arthax had sent his group after the elf.
5. Instead the tied man, terrified, rewrites the story to save his own skin: they were minding their business trying to walk on with the elf; the giant animal turned on his companion for no reason, killed one of them who never even had his weapons out — and the guards search the dead man and confirm his dagger and scimitar are still sheathed.
6. Nuberroca cracks the bandit at his side with an intimidation, and the confession comes out through the fear: Arthax had told them to kidnap the elf, they couldn't find him, and then a semi-orc appeared who wasn't there before — some magic mixed up in it. Amidamaru, still invisible, drops the spell and steps in from behind, calling to the guards that the bandits wanted to rob him, he had to hide, and asking what's going on. The bandit stares at him — that, that's the elf.
7. The guard-sergeant gives the party a chance to sway the crowd — they all try in turn; nothing lands. The crowd testifies against them — the bandits were bad people, everyone knows, but they weren't hurting anyone now, and the party had attacked them cold.
8. Nuberroca protests — the man just confessed a kidnap plan. Attempted kidnap, the guard answers, is not the same crime as kidnap; the party is not walking away from a dead man in the street this easily. Nuberroca, Nyx, and Eguzkilore are led off in custody — a fast hearing rather than a full trial. Amidamaru is not taken. Mialee and Sinsong sleep through the whole thing at the tavern.